

LAND OF OBEDIENCES and virtues



▲ Status symbols

Most wives worked hard on domestic chores. Elite women of the Manchu court were an exception, and wore elaborate fingernail covers to show they did not partake in manual labor.

THE QING DYNASTY

After the Tang Dynasty (618–907 CE), a golden age in China (see pp. 48–49), Chinese women experienced a setback in terms of freedoms and rights. Confucian ideology, which stressed the submission of women, became prevalent. According to the ideology, a virtuous woman was “she who hath no talent.”

Moral lessons

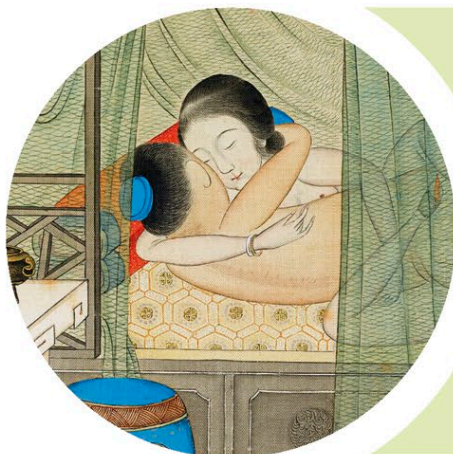
By the time of the Qing Dynasty (1644–1912), women’s virtue was directly linked to the well-being and authority of the state. The doctrine of the Three Obediences and Four Virtues (see pp. 80–81) developed in ancient China. Stressing patriarchal obedience and moral values, it formed the basis of female education from the age of around ten, when girls were segregated from their brothers. In line with the three obediences, girls were expected to obey their father, wives their husbands, and widows their sons. “Moral

discipline, proper speech manner, modest appearance, and diligence” constituted the four virtues. Chastity for unmarried women was a central tenet of this doctrine and the foundation of a young girl’s honor. Apart from these teachings, a girl’s education consisted of lessons in household affairs, food and wine appreciation, deportment, and makeup. Women who possessed more than a basic level of literacy were often regarded with suspicion; literacy was traditionally associated with courtesans, and learning was therefore seen as a corrupting influence.

The “cult of chastity”

became a state-sponsored movement that ran from 1736 to 1795, honoring chastity martyrs with statues, memorial shrines, and canonization. This state valorization encouraged single women to kill themselves rather than lose their virginity, and, along with the practice of female infanticide, only

**1-1.5
million people
worked in
prostitution at
the start of the
Qing Dynasty**



► Sensual pleasures

Qing China’s complex relationship with sexuality was the result of Confucian puritanism, which began to trump the more libertine Daoist philosophy of the previous period. Erotic artworks, however, continued to be commissioned during the Qing era.

**“VEHEMENT IN
HER CHASTITY,
[SHE] SACRIFICED
HER LIFE.”**

QING MAGISTRATE RECOMMENDING THE CANONIZATION OF AGUAN, A CHASTITY MARTYR, 1752